The "Why's" Behind the Do's & Don'ts

Our resume templates are designed to maximize your chances of getting you an interview. If a job gets 500 applications, the person in charge of hiring might only fully read a few dozen resumes.

To be successful, a resume must pass the following "tests" (in order):

1. **Make it past the Applicant Tracking Software (ATS)**

   What is ATS?
   A digital filing cabinet; Used by employers to manage the hiring process. It's a specialized search engine for the employer's hiring department.

   What types of employers use ATS?
   - More than 90% of recruitment and staffing professionals and fortune 500 companies
   - More than 70% of large businesses
   - Around 30% of small to midsized businesses; this percentage is rising fast.

   ATS software does the following:
   - "Reads" the resume, stripping away formatting to identify contact information, work history, skills, and education.
   - Ranks the resume against the job description. It looks for keywords that match what was in the original job posting and applies a score to show how much it matches what the employer is looking for.
   - Filters out applications, allowing employers to focus on more likely matches.

2. **Get ranked high enough by ATS to make it in front of the recruiter.**
   Assuming the resume can be understood by ATS, it must have enough of the keywords to rank high enough to get pushed to the recruiter.

3. **Get past the recruiters' initial glance (information processing)**
   The recruiter doesn't read every single resume that makes it to them. They first glance at it, and within the first 8 seconds, decide if they are going to continue reading or toss it aside. Recruiters naturally gravitate towards resumes that are easier to scan quickly.

   Recruiters make this decision based upon several factors:
   - How easy the important information is to visually process (keywords, skills, employment dates, job titles, education/certifications)
   - Most recruiters follow an "F-Shape" or "Z-Shape" Pattern which is how we generally scan printed information.
   - Snap judgements made based on how the resume visually looks
   - Whether the information that does grab their attention indicates the applicant is worth spending more time on

4. **Avoid negative judgements based on age, ethnicity, employment gaps, etc.**
   There's certain information that can be left out (and is in fact better to leave out) of a resume. The recruiter may make a negative judgement based on any number of irrelevant factors.

5. **Show the recruiter that the applicant has the skill and experience they are looking for.**
   This has to do with the information that is included in the resume and making sure to include what the job posting asked for. The quality of the resume's formatting and writing can also contribute to this. If the recruiter is looking for someone who is detail-oriented and good with written communication, the resume needs to showcase those skills and avoid typos and grammatical errors.